

CHAPTER TWELVE

Recovering After Mistakes

(A Strand Chapter – read this one slowly.)

Hi, friend. It's me again. The narrator. The grandfather voice. J.A.R.

This is the second strand chapter. The strand chapters are where I step out of the story for a minute and talk to you directly, because some things are best said straight, without a character in the way.

This chapter is about what to do *after* you have made a mistake. We have spent a lot of time, in this book, on the *during* of a mistake – the lying, the bumping, the staying quiet, the not standing up. But what about the after?

The after is where most adults get stuck.

Here is the secret. Most adults you know have made a mistake – sometimes a small one, sometimes a big one – that they have not figured out how to put down. They are still carrying it. They have been carrying it for a year, or five years, or twenty years, or forty. They do not always know they are carrying it. But they are.

I want you to learn, now, while you are eight and nine and ten, what to do after. So you do not have to carry these things into your thirties and forties and beyond.

Here is the toolkit for recovering after a mistake.

1. NAME THE MISTAKE.

Say it out loud, or write it down, in plain words. Not *I did kind of a not-great thing*. Not *something happened*. The plain language. *I lied to my mom about my homework*. *I said something unkind to my friend*. *I broke a thing on purpose*. *I did not stand up for someone who needed me to*.

Naming the mistake takes away its power. The mistake gets smaller the moment you name it. Try this. The next time you have done something you are not proud of, say it out loud, alone in your room, in plain words. Notice what happens in your chest.

2. NAME THE IMPACT.

What did the mistake do to the other person? What did it do to you? Be honest. Do not minimize. Do not catastrophize. Just describe. *My mom was disappointed*. *I felt bad for two days*. *My friend was sad*. *They had to walk to school alone*.

The impact is what tells you what the apology needs to address.

3. APOLOGIZE — IF YOU CAN.

You learned this in first grade. The three-part apology. *I name what I did*. *I name how it hurt*. *I name what will change*. You can review the three parts now if you have forgotten. They have not changed.

If you can — because sometimes the person you need to apologize to is far away, or gone, or not safe to be in contact with. In those cases, you can write an apology you do not send. You can apologize in your journal. You can apologize at a grave, or to a memory, or to your reflection in a window. The apology still does work, even if the person does not hear it. You hear it. Your inside hears it. That is some of the work.

4. REPAIR — IF YOU CAN.

Repair means doing something to fix the thing you broke. If you took someone's pencil, you give it back. If you said

something unkind, you take it back and you also say something kind. If you let someone down, you show up for them next time. If you lied, you tell the truth.

Repair is not always possible. Some things cannot be fixed. (You cannot un-say a mean thing. You can only do the next thing.) The repair is sometimes not the original thing. The repair is sometimes the changed behavior going forward. Both count.

5. LEARN.

What did this mistake teach you? What will you do differently next time? Write it down. Tell somebody.

The learning is what turns the mistake into something useful. A mistake without learning is just damage. A mistake with learning is — and I am going to say this carefully because it is important — a mistake with learning is worth something. The mistake is paying you back, in the currency of wisdom. That is the deal.

6. PUT IT DOWN.

This is the part most adults can't do. They name, they apologize, they repair, they learn — and they still keep carrying.

You do not have to keep carrying.

When the work is done, you put it down. You walk away. You let it be a thing that happened, not a thing that is.

How do you know the work is done? Here are some signs.

The other person has forgiven you, or you have made the best repair you can. You have changed your behavior in a real way. You can say the mistake out loud without your chest getting tight. You can think about it without feeling small.

When those signs are there — you can put it down. The mistake is allowed to be in the past. You are allowed to move forward.

If the chest-tight feeling comes back later — that is okay. Pick it up. Look at it. Put it back down. The practice of putting things down is the whole practice. Some things you put down once and they stay down. Some things you put down a hundred times. The picking-up-and-putting-down is not failure. It is just how it works.

7. TELL A TRUSTED ADULT IF YOU ARE STUCK.

If the mistake is too big, or too old, or too heavy, or if it involves something that scares you, or someone who is not safe — you tell a trusted adult. You do not work on it alone. The trusted adult is part of the recovery.

When you tell a trusted adult, you are not asking them to fix it. You are asking them to help you carry it for a minute, so you can figure out what to do.

That is what trusted adults are for. They are not in your life to judge you. They are in your life to carry with you the things that are too heavy for one nine-year-old to carry alone.

This is how recovery from a mistake works.

I want you to know — and this is the most important thing in this chapter — every single adult you respect has been through this process many times. The wise grown-ups in your life are wise because they have made mistakes, recovered, and learned. The wisdom is not separate from the mistakes. The wisdom is what the mistakes made.

You are going to make many mistakes in your life. Some of them will be small. Some of them will be enormous. None of them will be more than you can recover from.

You are going to be okay. You are going to be more than okay.

You are going to be the kind of grown-up that other kids look up to one day, because of how well you can recover from

a mistake. That starts now. With these seven steps. With this small piece of practice.

Read this chapter again the next time you make a mistake. The chapter is not going anywhere.

Okay. End of strand chapter. Back to the story.

— J.A.R.